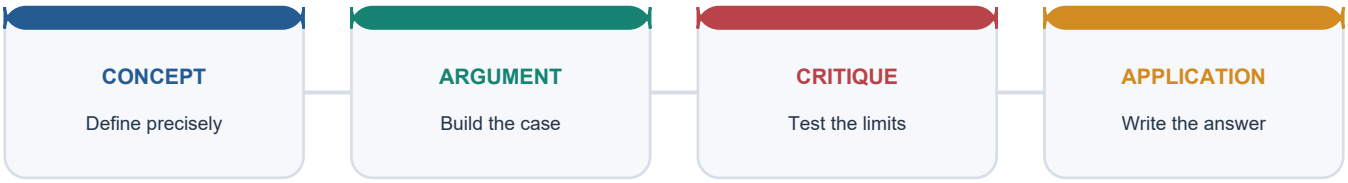
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Indian States & Society in the Eighteenth Century - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Content is drawn from this topic's own Basic and Advanced learning material, verified PYQs and original practice; no fabricated statistics or PYQs are used.

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Indian States & Society in the 18th Century (Marathas, Sikhs, successor states) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which power was an important ally of Ahmad Shah Abdali at Panipat?

Which power was an important ally of Ahmad Shah Abdali at Panipat?

A. Najib-ud-Daula of Rohilkhand B. Suraj Mal as a committed Maratha commander C. Murshid Quli Khan D. Martanda Varma

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: the Rohilla chief Najib-ud-Daula was a key ally supporting Abdali's coalition against the Marathas.
- **B.** Wrong: Suraj Mal engaged with the Marathas earlier but withdrew before the battle; he was not a committed Maratha commander at Panipat.
- **C.** Wrong: Murshid Quli Khan had died decades earlier (1727) and belongs to Bengal, unconnected to the Panipat campaign.
- **D.** Wrong: Martanda Varma ruled Travancore in the far south, with no role in the north Indian Panipat campaign.

Trap logic: Do not confuse "ally" with "committed partner throughout" - Suraj Mal's late withdrawal is the key qualifying fact tested here.

Q2. The most accurate assessment of Panipat (1761) is that it

The most accurate assessment of Panipat (1761) is that it

A. immediately established Company rule across India B. severely damaged Maratha northern power but did not end Maratha recovery C. created permanent Afghan rule in India D. abolished the Peshwaship

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: Company territorial rule expanded later, from Bengal (1757/1765) onward, unconnected to Panipat's immediate aftermath.
- **B.** Correct: confirmed by Madhav Rao's later victories and the 1771 restoration of Shah Alam II to Delhi.
- **C.** Wrong: Abdali withdrew after the battle and did not establish lasting Indian administration.
- **D.** Wrong: the Peshwaship continued under Madhav Rao I and later Peshwas until 1818.

Trap logic: Distinguish a severe battlefield setback from a terminal, civilisation-ending event - both extremes in the options are wrong.

Q3. Which event best demonstrates post-Panipat Maratha recovery?

Which event best demonstrates post-Panipat Maratha recovery?

A. The founding of Jaipur in 1727 B. The execution of Banda in 1716 C. Restoration of Shah Alam II to Delhi in 1771 D. The 1717 Bengal appointment

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the founding of Jaipur in 1727 is a Rajput city-building event decades before Panipat, with no evidentiary link to the battle.
- **B.** Wrong: predates Panipat by 45 years and concerns Sikh, not Maratha, history.
- **C.** Correct: direct post-Panipat evidence of renewed Maratha northern reach under Madhav Rao I.

- **D.** Wrong: the 1717 Bengal appointment concerns Murshid Quli Khan's Bengal administration, a separate region and process from the Marathas or Panipat.

Trap logic: Match the evidence's date and actor precisely to "post-Panipat" - pre-1761 events cannot serve as recovery evidence regardless of topical proximity.

Q4. Why is the Shahu-Tarabai contest important?

Why is the Shahu-Tarabai contest important?

A. It ended local hereditary rights B. It was a British annexation dispute C. It created the Khalsa D. It enabled sardars and the Peshwa to bargain and reshape Maratha authority

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: hereditary watan/deshmukh rights persisted regardless of the succession contest.
- **B.** Wrong: this was an internal Maratha succession dispute, decades before British annexation politics.
- **C.** Wrong: the Khalsa was a Sikh institution founded in 1699, unconnected to the Maratha succession dispute.
- **D.** Correct: the contested succession opened space for sardars and the Peshwa to negotiate and reshape authority.

Trap logic: Do not import an unrelated institution (Khalsa) or a later colonial-era mechanism (annexation) into an internal-succession question.

Q5. The Khalsa was established by Guru Gobind Singh in

The Khalsa was established by Guru Gobind Singh in

A. 1699 B. 1719 C. 1707 D. 1761

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: Guru Gobind Singh founded the Khalsa at Anandpur in 1699, the specific date this question tests.
- **B.** Wrong: 1719 is the year of the Mughal-Maratha sanads, not the Khalsa founding.
- **C.** Wrong: 1707 is Aurangzeb's death year, often confused with early-eighteenth-century foundational dates.
- **D.** Wrong: 1761 marks the Third Battle of Panipat, a Maratha-Afghan military clash with no connection to the Khalsa's founding.

Trap logic: Do not let adjacent memorable eighteenth-century dates (1707, 1719, 1761) substitute for the specific 1699 Khalsa foundation date.

Q6. Which act most clearly shows Banda Singh Bahadur moving from revolt toward state formation?

Which act most clearly shows Banda Singh Bahadur moving from revolt toward state formation?

A. Founding Hyderabad B. Appointing officials and using coin and seal C. Joining the English Company D. Accepting the Peshwaship

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: founding Hyderabad was Nizam-ul-Mulk's Deccan project, decades after and geographically apart from Banda's Punjab campaign.
- **B.** Correct: faujdars, a diwan, kardars, coin and seal are administrative and sovereign practices marking the shift from revolt to state formation.
- **C.** Wrong: anachronistic and factually false; Banda never allied with the Company.
- **D.** Wrong: the Peshwaship is the Maratha chief-minister office at Poona, an entirely separate institution from Banda's Sikh state-building acts.

Trap logic: Isolate the specific administrative markers (coin, seal, appointed officials) from generic or cross-topic distractors that merely sound like state-building.

Q7. Which statement about Banda Singh Bahadur's social base is most accurate?

Which statement about Banda Singh Bahadur's social base is most accurate?

A. Every Khatri merchant supported him B. It had no agrarian dimension C. It included Jat peasants and smaller zamindars but was not socially unanimous D. Only Mughal nobles supported him

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: overstates unanimity; some Khatri commercial interests sided with the Mughals.
- **B.** Wrong: Jat peasants and smaller zamindars were central to his mobilisation.
- **C.** Correct: support included Jat peasants and smaller zamindars but was not socially unanimous.
- **D.** Wrong: directly contradicts his base, which opposed Mughal authority.

Trap logic: Reject absolute or unanimous-sounding options ("every," "only," "no ... dimension") in favour of the qualified, evidence-matched description.

Q8. How should the number of Sikh misls be written in an evidence-disciplined answer?

How should the number of Sikh misls be written in an evidence-disciplined answer?

A. Exactly twelve unchanging units from 1699 B. All bands were provinces of Awadh C. No misls existed before 1809 D. Twelve major misls in conventional classification, with fluid contemporary groupings

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: conflates the 1699 Khalsa founding date with the much-later, fluid misl classification.
- **B.** Wrong: misls were autonomous Sikh formations, not Awadh provinces.
- **C.** Wrong: misls developed through the mid-to-late eighteenth century, well before 1809.
- **D.** Correct: twelve is a conventional classroom classification; contemporary groupings were fluid.

Trap logic: The "conventional twelve" is a later classroom shorthand - qualify it with source fluidity rather than presenting it as a fixed original count.

Q9. The Dal Khalsa represented

The Dal Khalsa represented

A. collective Sikh mobilisation above individual misls B. the Maratha royal council C. the Bengal treasury D. the Mughal revenue ministry

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: the Dal Khalsa enabled collective Sikh action above individual misls.
- **B.** Wrong: the closest Maratha equivalent was the Peshwa-led council at Poona, not a Sikh collective body; it belongs to a different confederacy.
- **C.** Wrong: the Bengal treasury was administered under Murshid Quli Khan's successors and financiers such as the Jagat Seths, with no Sikh collective role.
- **D.** Wrong: Mughal revenue was managed through diwans and amils under imperial authority, a separate administrative track from Sikh misl politics.

Trap logic: Do not let institution names from other regional systems (Maratha, Bengal, Mughal) substitute for the specific Sikh collective body being asked about.

Q10. Why is Ranjit Singh bounded in this topic?

Why is Ranjit Singh bounded in this topic?

A. He fought at Panipat in 1761 B. He represents late-century consolidation after the misl phase C. He created Rohilkhand D. He founded the Khalsa in 1699

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: he was not born until 1780, making this factually impossible.
- **B.** Correct: his 1799 capture of Lahore represents late-century consolidation after the misl phase.
- **C.** Wrong: Rohilkhand was Afghan/Rohilla military settlement, unconnected to Ranjit Singh.
- **D.** Wrong: the Khalsa was founded by Guru Gobind Singh, decades before Ranjit Singh's birth.

Trap logic: Watch for chronologically impossible attributions - Ranjit Singh's 1780 birth year rules out any pre-1780 involvement.

Q11. The Mysore kingdom's historical genealogy is most closely linked to

The Mysore kingdom's historical genealogy is most closely linked to

A. the Sikh misls B. the Durrani Empire C. the Vijayanagara political order D. the Portuguese Estado da India

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the Sikh misls trace to Punjab's Khalsa-Dal Khalsa lineage, a separate line from Mysore's Deccan genealogy.
- **B.** Wrong: the Durrani Empire descends from Ahmad Shah Abdali's Afghan line, with no genealogical connection to Mysore's Wodeyar-Vijayanagara descent.
- **C.** Correct: the Wodeyar kingdom emerged from the post-Vijayanagara regional field.
- **D.** Wrong: the Estado da India was a Portuguese maritime enclave on the western coast, institutionally distinct from Mysore's inland Vijayanagara-derived kingdom.

Trap logic: Do not let "older regional kingdom" cues default to a Deccan-Muslim or European lineage - Mysore's specific genealogy runs through Vijayanagara.

Q12. Which reform is associated with Haidar Ali's military consolidation?

Which reform is associated with Haidar Ali's military consolidation?

A. The 1719 Maratha sanad B. Abolition of all land taxes C. Creation of the Jagat Seth bank D. A modern arsenal at Dindigul with French assistance

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the 1719 sanads were Maratha chauth/sardeshmukhi grants from the Mughal court, unconnected to Haidar Ali's Mysore army reforms.
- **B.** Wrong: factually false; land revenue remained central to Mysore's finances.
- **C.** Wrong: Jagat Seth is a Bengal banking house, unconnected to Mysore.
- **D.** Correct: the Dindigul arsenal and French-assisted trained units strengthened Mysore's military capability.

Trap logic: Do not transplant Bengal-banking or Maratha-fiscal facts onto a Mysore military-reform question - match institution to state precisely.

Q13. Tipu Sultan's later use of his own name in coinage and khutba most strongly indicates

Tipu Sultan's later use of his own name in coinage and khutba most strongly indicates

A. a sharper assertion of sovereignty than most successor states B. membership in the Dal Khalsa C. submission to the Peshwa D. direct Mughal control

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: the symbolism marked a sharper, more explicit sovereignty claim than most successor states.
- **B.** Wrong: the Dal Khalsa was a Punjab Sikh collective body, with no bearing on Tipu Sultan's Mysore sovereignty symbolism.
- **C.** Wrong: submission to the Peshwa would mean acknowledging Maratha overlordship, the opposite of Tipu's assertive self-naming on coinage and khutba.
- **D.** Wrong: contradicts the very act of replacing Mughal symbolism with his own name.

Trap logic: Coinage/khutba in the ruler's own name signals an assertion of independent sovereignty, the opposite of submission or external control.

Q14. Martanda Varma strengthened Travancore mainly through

Martanda Varma strengthened Travancore mainly through

A. Company Diwani B. military centralisation, trade monopoly and public works C. Mughal mansabdari alone D. Sikh conquest shares

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the Diwani is the 1765 Bengal revenue-collection grant to the Company, a distinct eastern-region institution from Travancore's own reforms.
- **B.** Correct: army reform, suppression of feudatories, pepper revenue and communication works reinforced the state.
- **C.** Wrong: Travancore lay outside core Mughal mansab administration; this understates his specific reforms.
- **D.** Wrong: patti/misl conquest shares were a Punjab Sikh military-fiscal arrangement, institutionally separate from Martanda Varma's Travancore reforms.

Trap logic: Do not substitute institutions from unrelated regions (Bengal Diwani, Sikh patti shares) for Travancore's own documented reform package.

Q15. Who consolidated the Jat kingdom of Bharatpur at its eighteenth-century height?

Who consolidated the Jat kingdom of Bharatpur at its eighteenth-century height?

A. Najib-ud-Daula B. Churaman alone C. Suraj Mal D. Nizam Ali Khan

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: Najib-ud-Daula was a Rohilla Afghan chief active in Rohilkhand and Delhi politics, not a Jat ruler of Bharatpur.
- **B.** Wrong: Churaman built early Jat power with Badan Singh, but did not alone reach the kingdom's eighteenth-century height.
- **C.** Correct: Suraj Mal expanded and centralised Bharatpur to its peak strength.
- **D.** Wrong: Nizam Ali Khan ruled Hyderabad in the Deccan, a separate successor state from the Jat kingdom of Bharatpur.

Trap logic: Distinguish the founding generation (Churaman, Badan Singh) from the consolidator who brought the kingdom to its height (Suraj Mal).

Q16. Sawai Jai Singh II is correctly associated with

Sawai Jai Singh II is correctly associated with

A. the Bhangi misl B. the Treaty of Mangalore C. Murshidabad's mint D. Jaipur and monumental astronomical observatories

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: the Bhangi misl was a Punjab Sikh territorial confederacy, unconnected to Jai Singh's Rajput astronomy and city-building work.
- **B.** Wrong: the Treaty of Mangalore (1784) closed an Anglo-Mysore war under Tipu Sultan, decades after and unrelated to Jai Singh's career.
- **C.** Wrong: Murshidabad's mint served Bengal's Nawabi currency system, an institution with no link to Jaipur or Jai Singh's observatories.
- **D.** Correct: Jaipur's founding and the Jantar Mantar observatories are his signature achievements.

Trap logic: Do not let unrelated regional institutions substitute for Jai Singh's specific, verifiable achievements (Jaipur, Jantar Mantar).

Q17. Rohilkhand emerged primarily from

Rohilkhand emerged primarily from

A. Afghan military settlement amid Mughal weakening B. territory occupied and granted by Durrani C. a Portuguese coastal factory D. a Travancore succession

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: Rohilkhand grew from Afghan military settlement as Mughal authority weakened.
- **B.** Wrong: reverses the actual relationship; Durrani later allied with, but did not found, Rohilla power.
- **C.** Wrong: Portuguese coastal factories were maritime trade enclaves on the western seaboard, with no role in Rohilkhand's Afghan land settlement.
- **D.** Wrong: a Travancore succession dispute belongs to the far south under Martanda Varma's line, unconnected to Rohilkhand's north-Indian origin.

Trap logic: Do not backdate Durrani's later alliance into a founding role - Rohilkhand's origin precedes and is independent of Abdali's involvement.

Q18. The phrase military labour market refers to

The phrase military labour market refers to

A. European troops alone B. mobile soldiers and commanders offering service across competing courts C. unpaid village police D. a permanent caste with one ruler only

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: understates the market's diverse, largely Indian composition.
- **B.** Correct: mobile soldiers and commanders offered paid service across competing courts.
- **C.** Wrong: contradicts the paid, mobile, cross-court nature of the market.
- **D.** Wrong: contradicts the mobility and multi-court service that defines the concept.

Trap logic: The term describes cross-court mobility and paid service, not a fixed, single-employer or unpaid arrangement.

Q19. Ijara or ijaradari was

Ijara or ijaradari was

A. a Sikh initiation rite B. a Mughal coin legend C. revenue farming to a contractor for a fixed promised sum D. a Maratha fort category

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: a Sikh initiation rite refers to Khalsa Amrit Sanchar practice, a religious ceremony with no fiscal meaning.
- **B.** Wrong: a Mughal coin legend is the ruler's inscribed title on currency, a numismatic detail distinct from a revenue-farming contract.
- **C.** Correct: ijara was revenue farming to a contractor for a fixed promised sum.
- **D.** Wrong: a Maratha fort category classifies hill or plains forts, a military-architectural term unrelated to revenue contracting.

Trap logic: Do not confuse a fiscal-administrative term (revenue farming) with unrelated religious, numismatic or military categories that appear in the same century.

Q20. Peshkash most commonly denoted

Peshkash most commonly denoted

A. a village share of chauth B. an artillery drill C. a European sea pass D. tribute or payment acknowledging a superior authority

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: conflates Maratha fiscal terminology with a distinct tribute concept.
- **B.** Wrong: an artillery drill is a military-training exercise, unconnected to the tribute meaning of peshkash.
- **C.** Wrong: a European sea pass (cartaz/dastak-type permit) authorised maritime trade, a commercial-navigation term distinct from tribute payment.
- **D.** Correct: peshkash was tribute or payment acknowledging a superior authority.

Trap logic: Peshkash is specifically a tribute/acknowledgment payment - do not merge it with unrelated fiscal, military or maritime terms sharing the same historical period.

Q21. Which is the most accurate description of the banker-state-company relationship?

Which is the most accurate description of the banker-state-company relationship?

A. A shifting triangle of credit, security, trade privilege and political leverage B. States did not need credit C. Bankers always served the Company D. Companies had no Indian partners

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: bankers pursued repayment and access; their alignments varied by region and political moment.
- **B.** Wrong: directly contradicts the well-documented reliance of states on bankers for remittance and campaign finance.
- **C.** Wrong: overstates alignment; bankers' loyalties shifted by context, as with the Jagat Seths' complex position before Plassey.
- **D.** Wrong: contradicts the Company's dependence on Indian bankers and merchants.

Trap logic: Reject any option using "always" or "never" for banker alignment - the relationship was genuinely variable and multi-directional.

Q22. A hundi was important because it

A hundi was important because it

A. abolished customs B. transferred credit and remittance across commercial networks C. defined a Sikh misl D. served as a fort cannon

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: customs abolition is a tariff-policy act, with no connection to a hundi's function as a credit instrument.
- **B.** Correct: hundis transferred credit and remittance across commercial networks.
- **C.** Wrong: a misl is a Sikh territorial-military confederacy, a political category unrelated to a hundi's financial function.
- **D.** Wrong: a fort cannon is military hardware, categorically distinct from a hundi's role as a credit-transfer bill.

Trap logic: A hundi is a financial-credit instrument - do not let unrelated political or military terms from the same century substitute for its actual function.

Q23. Which set contains important eighteenth-century textile or craft centres?

Which set contains important eighteenth-century textile or craft centres?

A. Lahore fort, Raigad, Arcot and Rohilkhand only B. Anandpur, Satara, Kabul and Mangalore only C. Dacca, Murshidabad, Banaras and Masulipatnam D. Panipat battlefield, Palkhed, Karnal and Plassey only

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: mixes forts and political capitals, none of which is a primary textile hub.
- **B.** Wrong: mixes Sikh/Maratha/Afghan political centres, not craft centres.
- **C.** Correct: Dacca, Murshidabad, Banaras and Masulipatnam were major manufacturing/commercial centres.
- **D.** Wrong: these are battle sites, not craft or commercial centres.

Trap logic: Do not let politically or militarily famous place names substitute for the specific, separately documented commercial-manufacturing centres.

Q24. What happened to Bengal's trade under Maratha pressure and European expansion?

What happened to Bengal's trade under Maratha pressure and European expansion?

A. Only inland trade grew B. European companies withdrew C. All trade ended permanently D. Some overland trade suffered while oceanic European trade expanded

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: overstates one direction while ignoring documented overland disruption.
- **B.** Wrong: contradicts the well-documented expansion of European oceanic trade in this period.
- **C.** Wrong: contradicts continued textile production and oceanic commerce.
- **D.** Correct: some overland trade suffered while oceanic European trade expanded - a route-specific, not uniform, pattern.

Trap logic: Reject uniform "all" or "only" claims - the evidence supports a divergent, route-specific pattern, not a single aggregate trend.

Q25. Which statement best captures caste and mobility in the century?

Which statement best captures caste and mobility in the century?

A. Hierarchy remained strong, but service could raise selected individuals and lineages B. Caste disappeared under regional states C. Political power always followed ritual rank D. No social mobility existed

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: hierarchy persisted, but military/fiscal service enabled selective mobility, as the Holkar rise shows.
- **B.** Wrong: contradicts the persistence of caste hierarchy throughout the century.
- **C.** Wrong: contradicts cases like Holkar's rise through military service rather than ritual rank.
- **D.** Wrong: contradicts documented cases of service-based mobility.

Trap logic: The correct answer holds both persistence and selective mobility together - avoid options that assert either total rigidity or total fluidity.

Q26. Why must women's history be written with explicit source limits?

Why must women's history be written with explicit source limits?

A. Court chronicles provide full village data B. Elite and spectacular practices are over-recorded relative to ordinary labour C. All regions followed one matrilineal system D. Women left no historical evidence at all

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: chronicles are elite-focused, not comprehensive village-level sources.
- **B.** Correct: elite and spectacular practices (e.g. Tarabai, Ahilyabai) are over-recorded relative to ordinary agricultural and craft labour.
- **C.** Wrong: overstates uniformity across a socially diverse subcontinent.
- **D.** Wrong: contradicts visible evidence for figures like Tarabai and Ahilyabai.

Trap logic: The issue is uneven source visibility (elite over ordinary), not total absence of evidence or false claims of regional uniformity.

Q27. Which statement about eighteenth-century political alliances is most accurate?

Which statement about eighteenth-century political alliances is most accurate?

A. All wars were religious B. Only Europeans crossed religious lines C. Revenue, strategy and faction usually mattered more than communal blocs D. Hindus and Muslims never allied

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: contradicts numerous cross-religious alliances documented in the period.
- **B.** Wrong: contradicts Indian examples like Awadh-Maratha-Jat cooperation.
- **C.** Correct: revenue, strategy and faction usually outweighed communal blocs in alliance-making.
- **D.** Wrong: directly contradicted by Awadh-Maratha-Jat and Abdali-Rohilla-Awadh coalitions.

Trap logic: Reject absolute claims about religious alignment - named cross-religious coalitions are the direct counter-evidence.

Q28. The migration of artists from Delhi to regional courts best supports which argument?

The migration of artists from Delhi to regional courts best supports which argument?

A. All Mughal art ended in 1707 B. Only European art survived C. Regional culture had no Persianate influence D. Patronage was redistributed rather than uniformly extinguished

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: contradicts continued Mughal-style production at regional courts.
- **B.** Wrong: contradicts the flourishing of Persianate-regional schools.
- **C.** Wrong: contradicts continued Persianate-vernacular artistic idioms at regional courts.
- **D.** Correct: patronage was redistributed to regional courts rather than uniformly extinguished.

Trap logic: Migration evidence supports redistribution of patronage, not the extinction or exclusive survival of any one artistic tradition.

Q29. Which phrase best describes institutional change in successor states?

Which phrase best describes institutional change in successor states?

A. Continuity of grammar, change of authorship B. Unchanged direct rule from Delhi C. Complete administrative invention D. Modern federalism

Answer: A.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Correct: old vocabulary and forms survived while regional rulers, elites and financiers controlled them.
- **B.** Wrong: contradicts the shift of effective control to regional rulers.
- **C.** Wrong: contradicts the demonstrated continuity of Mughal vocabulary and offices.
- **D.** Wrong: anachronistic; no such constitutional arrangement existed.

Trap logic: The correct phrase captures continuity of form with a change of controlling authority - avoid options claiming either total continuity or total invention.

Q30. Which is a genuine institutional innovation of the century?

Which is a genuine institutional innovation of the century?

A. Abolition of all intermediaries everywhere B. Misl conquest shares and selective direct revenue systems in Mysore C. The disappearance of coinage D. Uniform parliamentary government

Answer: B.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: contradicts the persistence of zamindars, jagirdars and revenue farmers throughout the century.
- **B.** Correct: misl patti shares and Mysore's selective direct revenue systems were genuine new arrangements.
- **C.** Wrong: contradicts continued and even assertive use of coinage, as with Tipu Sultan.
- **D.** Wrong: uniform parliamentary government is a later constitutional form with no eighteenth-century Indian precedent, unlike the misl and Mysore innovations named in option B.

Trap logic: Genuine innovation appears in specific new arrangements (misl patti shares, Mysore's direct revenue systems), not in sweeping, era-wide institutional claims.

Q31. A fiscal-military state is one that

A fiscal-military state is one that

A. separates taxation from war completely B. depends only on ritual authority C. turns revenue and credit into sustained military capacity D. has no merchants or officials

Answer: C.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: contradicts the defining fusion of revenue and military capacity.
- **B.** Wrong: contradicts the material revenue-army basis of such states.
- **C.** Correct: a fiscal-military state converts revenue and credit into sustained military capacity.
- **D.** Wrong: contradicts the central role of bankers, revenue farmers and officials in sustaining these states.

Trap logic: The defining feature is the revenue-credit-army loop - reject options that sever taxation from military capacity or deny the state's administrative apparatus.

Q32. Which factor most clearly distinguished the Company's later fiscal-military system?

Which factor most clearly distinguished the Company's later fiscal-military system?

A. No reliance on alliances B. Absence of Indian bankers C. Exclusive use of European soldiers D. Integration of territorial revenue, corporate credit, unified command and maritime supply

Answer: D.

Explanation by option:

- **A.** Wrong: contradicts the Company's extensive use of diplomacy to isolate opponents.
- **B.** Wrong: contradicts heavy reliance on Indian credit and remittance networks.
- **C.** Wrong: contradicts the Company's predominantly Indian sepoy army.
- **D.** Correct: the Company integrated territorial revenue, corporate credit, unified command and maritime supply into one durable structure.

Trap logic: The Company's advantage was integration of existing elements (revenue, credit, command, supply), not the exclusion of Indian participants or alliances.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PART II - VERIFIED/ROUTED PYQS WITH SOLUTIONS

PYQ 01 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q48: eighteenth-century successor states

Verified question: With reference to Indian history, which of the following statements is/are correct?

1. The Nizamat of Arcot emerged out of Hyderabad State.
2. The Mysore Kingdom emerged out of Vijayanagara Empire.
3. Rohilkhand Kingdom was formed out of the territories occupied by Ahmad Shah Durrani.

- A. 1 only
- B. 1 and 2 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 3 only

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: B, 1 and 2 only. **Confidence:** high.

Solved explanation

- Statement 1 is correct in the conventional political genealogy: the Carnatic or Nizamat of Arcot developed within the Deccan-Hyderabad hierarchy before its Nawabs gained practical autonomy.
- Statement 2 is correct: the Wodeyar kingdom of Mysore grew from the political field of the Vijayanagara Empire.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: Rohilkhand grew from Afghan military settlement and weakening Mughal authority; Ahmad Shah Durrani later allied with Rohilla power but did not create the state from occupied territory.
- The question tests origin, not merely chronology. It distinguishes successor/subordinate formations from a later invader's sphere.

Why this earns marks: It tests each statement independently, names the predecessor polity, corrects the backward projection of Durrani and labels the answer as inferred because the local official key is unavailable.

Demand decoding: This is a three-statement genealogy question (Prelims, no marks weighting beyond +2/-0.66): each statement must be checked against a named predecessor polity, not a general impression of "successor states".

Why the correct combination is B, not A, C or D: Statement 1 (Arcot from Hyderabad) and Statement 2 (Mysore from Vijayanagara) are both independently verifiable from named political genealogies; Statement 3 fails on a specific, checkable point - Durrani's alliance with the Rohillas came after their settlement, not before it, so he did not found Rohilkhand.

Compression plan for the exam: Evaluate each of the three statements independently in under 20 seconds each; eliminate any option containing a statement you have disproved; do not let two correct statements tempt you into an "all three" answer.

How to improve recall of this item: Keep a one-line genealogy note for each of the three polities (Arcot <- Hyderabad; Mysore <- Vijayanagara; Rohilkhand <- Afghan military settlement, not Durrani conquest) rather than a single merged "successor states" fact.

PYQ 02 - 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45: Mughal administrative hierarchy

Verified question: With reference to medieval India, which one of the following is the correct sequence in ascending order in terms of size?

- A. Pargana - Sarkar - Suba
- B. Sarkar - Pargana - Suba
- C. Suba - Sarkar - Pargana
- D. Pargana - Suba - Sarkar

INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED LOCALLY: A, Pargana - Sarkar - Suba. **Confidence:** high.

Routing note: This is an adjacent recall item, not a direct Topic-02 route. The direct owner is Medieval History Topic 24, which covers Mughal administrative-unit hierarchy. It is retained here only because regional states in Topic 02 appropriated this same vocabulary; the question itself tests Mughal, not eighteenth-century regional, administration.

Solved explanation

- A pargana grouped villages and was the smaller revenue-administrative unit in this sequence.
- A sarkar grouped parganas.
- A subah was the larger province containing sarkars.
- The hierarchy matters for Topic 02 because regional states usually appropriated Mughal territorial and fiscal machinery rather than creating administration from nothing.

Why this earns marks: It gives the exact ascending sequence and links the recall fact to institutional continuity, the analytical core of successor-state formation.

Demand decoding: This is a pure ascending-size ordering question with no dates or events to verify - the only task is fixing pargana < sarkar < subah correctly and not confusing it with a revenue-assessment sequence.

Why A is correct and the others are not: B and C reverse pargana and subah at opposite ends; D places subah in the middle. Only A keeps the correct nesting (villages grouped into a pargana, parganas grouped into a sarkar, sarkars grouped into a subah).

Compression plan for the exam: Recite the nesting from smallest to largest before reading the options, then match; do not let option ordering (A first vs D first) influence the answer.

How to improve recall of this item: Anchor the sequence to the Topic-02 point it supports - regional states such as Bengal and Awadh reused this same administrative ladder rather than inventing a new one - so the fact is remembered through its Topic-02 relevance, not in isolation.

PYQ 03 - 2022 GS-I Mains Q2: Company armies and Indian rulers

Verified adjacent question: Why did the armies of the British East India Company - mostly comprising Indian soldiers - win consistently against the more numerous and better equipped armies of the then Indian rulers? Give reasons. (10 marks, 150 words)

Routing note: The direct owner is Modern History Topic 05. It is included here because Topic 02 explains the multi-state fiscal-military field from which the Company emerged. The answer must not treat fragmentation as automatic defeat.

Model answer

The Company's advantage lay less in the ethnicity of its soldiers than in the organisation that made them a reliable fiscal-military force. Indian states possessed capable cavalry, artillery and revenue systems: Mysore created French-trained infantry, Ibrahim Khan Gardi served the Marathas, and Ranjit Singh later built a disciplined army. The issue was consistency.

The Company combined regular drill, infantry-artillery coordination, unified command and reliable payment. Coastal bases and the British naval network sustained supply. London credit and Indian bankers financed long campaigns, while diplomacy isolated opponents: Mysore, Maratha and Sikh forces were usually fought in separate wars with Indian allies on the Company side. After **Plassey (1757)** and especially the **Diwani (1765)**, Bengal revenue funded troops and further conquest.

Yet victory was contingent: Haidar Ali reached Madras, the Treaty of Mangalore was negotiated, the First Anglo-Maratha War ended at Salbai, and Punjab remained independent under Ranjit Singh. The decisive edge was the cumulative integration of command, credit, revenue, supply and alliance, not inherent European superiority.

Why this earns marks: It answers "why" through linked mechanisms, uses named counter-evidence, distinguishes capability from identity and ends with a qualified causal verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **give reasons** requires organisational/institutional causes of a *consistent* Company advantage, not a single-battle narrative and not an ethnic or racial explanation - "mostly Indian soldiers" in the question itself blocks that reading.

Why this is a 10-mark, 150-word answer, not longer: the question asks for reasons only, with no comparison or periodisation demanded, so the model stays inside four short paragraphs: named counter-evidence (Mysore, Marathas, Ranjit Singh had capable forces too), the Company's specific integration (drill, command, credit, supply, alliance), the 1757/1765 turning points, and the anti-inevitability qualification (Mangalore, Salbai, Ranjit Singh's Punjab).

Compression plan for the exam: One sentence stating the organisational thesis; one sentence of named counter-evidence against a racial/technological explanation; two sentences on the Company's specific integration; one qualifying sentence - five sentences fit 150 words.

How to improve this answer: Add the single named fact that most sharply falsifies a "European technology" reading - Ibrahim Khan Gardi's European-drilled Maratha artillery at Panipat - and state explicitly that it proves the advantage was organisational integration, not technology alone.

PYQ coverage conclusion

Exactly one direct Topic-02 route exists in the audited local record: 2021 Prelims GS-I Q48 on successor-state genealogy. 2021 Prelims GS-I Q45 (administrative hierarchy) is adjacent and belongs to Medieval Topic 24. No direct GS-I Mains question confined to eighteenth-century regional states appears in the audited local record; the verified 2022 GS-I Mains Q2 (Company armies) is included only as an explicitly bounded bridge, with its direct ownership stated as Topic 05. The direct Topic-02 route count for both 2026 Prelims and 2026 GS-I Mains is zero in the audited local record. No History Optional or unofficial coaching question is presented as a UPSC PYQ.

PART IV - ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Mains 10M-1 - Classify the major eighteenth-century Indian states and explain why the classification matters. (150 words)

Model answer

Eighteenth-century states are best classified by **origin and legitimacy**, not a simple strong/weak scale.

Mughal successor states - Bengal (Murshid Quli Khan), Awadh (Saadat Khan) and Hyderabad (Nizam-ul-Mulk) - converted provincial office into hereditary autonomy, retaining Mughal titles and coin/khutba symbolism while controlling appointments, revenue and war locally.

Resistance/confederate states - Marathas, Sikhs, Jats and Rohillas - grew through armed mobilisation and new fiscal claims. The 1719 sanads legalised chauth/sardeshmukhi, and Banda Singh Bahadur's coin, seal and officials, plus later Sikh misls, show routes from resistance to rule.

Older regional kingdoms - Mysore, Travancore and Rajput states - strengthened pre-existing polities: Haidar Ali's arsenal and Martanda Varma's army and pepper monopoly show explicit centralisation.

The classification matters: origin shaped resources and weaknesses - successor states borrowed imperial legitimacy, confederacies traded unity for reach, and older kingdoms still bargained with local elites - explaining regional vitality without one uncontested Mughal replacement.

Why this earns marks: It defines the classification criterion, names three evidence-rich categories, analyses why origin mattered and avoids equating autonomy with modern nation-state sovereignty.

Demand decoding: Classify demands a named criterion (not just a list of states) and **explain why it matters** demands a consequence, not a restatement of the classification itself.

Why this is a 10-mark, 150-word answer: one classification, three categories, one named example each, one sentence on why origin mattered - a 15- or 20-mark treatment would additionally require intra-category comparison, which this question does not ask for.

Compression plan for the exam: State the criterion (origin and legitimacy) in the first sentence; give one named example per category in three short paragraphs; close with one sentence on why the classification matters, not a second list.

How to improve this answer: Add the single sharpest example of the classification failing to predict strength - Bengal (successor state) was fiscally stronger than most confederate states, showing origin shaped *resources*, not automatically *power*.

Mains 10M-2 - The Third Battle of Panipat was a grave Maratha setback, not the end of Maratha power. Explain. (150 words)

Model answer

Panipat on **14 January 1761** destroyed a major Maratha expeditionary force and reduced Peshwa prestige, but did not terminate Maratha power.

The setback was strategic: **Sadashiv Rao Bhau** and Vishwas Rao were lost; long supply lines, factional command and damaged ties with Rajputs, Jats and Sikh chiefs left the army isolated, while **Ahmad Shah Abdali** secured Rohilla and Shuja-ud-Daula support. This exposed coalition and logistics failure, not an absence of trained infantry - **Ibrahim Khan Gardi** commanded a European-style force.

Its limits are clear too: Abdali did not establish durable Indian rule. Under **Madhav Rao I (1761-72)** the Marathas defeated the Nizam, pressured Haidar Ali and recovered north Indian influence, restoring Shah Alam II to Delhi in **1771**.

Panipat ended the immediate bid for northern paramountcy and opened space for rivals, including the Company, but did not abolish the confederacy - the decisive British-Maratha struggle still lay ahead.

Why this earns marks: It separates battlefield loss, political consequence and later recovery, names commanders and the 1771 evidence, and rejects both terminal and inevitability claims.

Demand decoding: Explain here means show the causal mechanism of the setback (why Panipat happened as it did) *and* the causal mechanism of recovery (why it was not terminal) - both halves must appear, not only the battle narrative.

Why this is a 10-mark, 150-word answer: it needs exactly one cause-of-defeat paragraph and one cause-of-recovery paragraph with named individuals and dates; a 20-mark version would additionally need the historiographical "inevitability" debate, which this question does not require.

Compression plan for the exam: One sentence dating the battle and its scale; one sentence naming the defeat's specific causes (coalition, supply, isolation); one sentence naming the specific recovery evidence (Madhav Rao I, 1771 restoration); one closing sentence stating the "setback, not end" verdict.

How to improve this answer: Add the precise mechanism-level distractor-killer - Ibrahim Khan Gardi's European-drilled Maratha artillery - to block the common wrong inference that the defeat proves Maratha military backwardness.

Mains 15M-1 - Compare state formation in Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad. (250 words)

Model answer

Bengal, Awadh and Hyderabad were all Mughal successor states, but converted provincial office into autonomy through different coalitions and constraints.

Common inheritance: each founder was an imperial servant - Murshid Quli Khan (Bengal), Saadat Khan (Awadh), Nizam-ul-Mulk (Hyderabad) - who retained Persian administration, titles and Mughal legitimacy while redirecting provincial revenue, appointments and force from Delhi toward a regional treasury and dynasty.

Bengal - fiscal-commercial coalition: Murshid Quli combined nazim and diwan authority in 1717, enforced revenue through large zamindars and sustained remittance. Textile and oceanic commerce elevated merchants and bankers; the **Jagat Seth** house became provincial treasurer in 1730. Alivardi Khan's rise with landed and banking support shows both strength and coalition dependence, though Maratha raids and growing European privilege were major vulnerabilities.

Awadh - landed-military accommodation: Saadat Khan subdued rebellious zamindars but usually confirmed them after payment. A separate fiscal establishment detached revenue from Delhi, while Muslim, Afghan and Hindu elites and a military labour market supported the state; Safdar Jang's use of Maratha and Jat allies shows pragmatic coalition-building, though refractory chiefs remained a constraint.

Hyderabad - patron-client Deccan order: Asaf Jah's 1724 victory created practical autonomy while coin and khutba retained the emperor. Local chiefs paid peshkash; traders, moneylenders and military aristocrats remained co-sharers, and diffused authority plus post-1748 succession conflict limited centralisation.

Thus the three shared Mughal institutional grammar but differed in social base: Bengal was most commercially financed, Awadh most dependent on landed-military accommodation, and Hyderabad most visibly a diffused

patron-client system.

Why this earns marks: It compares through common criteria - legitimacy, revenue, elite coalition and weakness - rather than narrating three states separately, and uses named institutions and bankers.

Demand decoding: Compare requires shared criteria applied across all three states (legitimacy, revenue base, elite coalition, constraint) - three separate mini-essays without cross-reference would lose marks even with correct facts.

Why this is a 15-mark, 250-word answer: three states, four comparison criteria each, plus one closing differentiation sentence is the right density for 250 words; fewer criteria would under-use the word budget, more would force superficial treatment.

Compression plan for the exam: One shared-inheritance sentence; one paragraph per state naming its founder, year and distinguishing coalition; one closing sentence naming the single sharpest point of difference (Bengal = commercial-fiscal, Awadh = landed-military, Hyderabad = patron-client diffusion).

How to improve this answer: Add a named post-founder complication for at least one state - Hyderabad's post-1748 succession conflict - to show state formation continuing to evolve rather than stopping at the founder's death.

Mains 15M-2 - Trace Sikh political transformation from the Khalsa to the misls. (250 words)

Model answer

Sikh political transformation in the eighteenth century moved non-linearly from disciplined community to territorial revolt and then to decentralised confederate power.

Khalsa foundation: in **1699**, Guru Gobind Singh established the Khalsa, using initiation and discipline to build a distinctive armed community. After his death in 1708, authority rested in the Panth and Granth rather than another personal Guru; not all Sikhs were Khalsa, and Jat peasants, Khatri traders and other groups had varied interests.

Banda Singh Bahadur: Banda mobilised Jat peasants and smaller zamindars under fiscal pressure, crossing from rebellion toward state formation by appointing faujdars, a diwan and kardars, and issuing orders under seal and coin. Support was uneven - some Jat zamindars and Khatri commercial interests sided with Mughal authority - and Mughal pressure and internal division led to his capture in 1715 and execution in 1716.

Misl phase: Sikh bands survived persecution and expanded amid disruption from Nadir Shah and Ahmad Shah Abdali. Territorial gains were distributed in pattis by contribution; the conventional count of twelve major misls masks fluid contemporary groupings. The **Dal Khalsa** enabled collective action above individual misls without abolishing chiefly autonomy.

Direction of change: the order mixed an egalitarian co-sharing ideal with growing chiefly power. This decentralised structure resisted Afghan control but could not produce permanent unified command - Ranjit Singh's 1799 capture of Lahore marks a later turn toward monarchy, not Sikh politics' starting point.

Why this earns marks: It traces institutions and social bases rather than a ruler list, reconciles the twelve-misl shorthand with source fluidity, and keeps Ranjit Singh within a clear boundary.

Demand decoding: Trace requires a strict chronological sequence with a named turning point at each stage (Khalsa -> Banda -> misls), not a thematic discussion of Sikh institutions out of order.

Why this is a 15-mark, 250-word answer: three chronological stages, each needing one founding fact, one named actor and one institutional detail, plus a closing statement on the direction of change, fits 250 words without needing a fourth (Ranjit Singh) stage, which this question deliberately excludes.

Compression plan for the exam: Date and describe the Khalsa (1699); describe Banda's administration and its 1715-16 end; describe the misl/Dal Khalsa phase and its co-sharing logic; close with one sentence on the direction of change (community to territorial power to confederate order) and explicitly bound Ranjit Singh out of the answer.

How to improve this answer: Add the specific qualifying fact that support for Banda was uneven (some Jat zamindars and Khatri interests sided with Mughal authority), which prevents the answer from implying a single unified Sikh political bloc throughout.

Mains 20M-1 - Was the eighteenth century a dark age, a transition or an age of regional resurgence? Critically discuss. (250 words)

Model answer

No single label fits the eighteenth century because political, economic, social and cultural change moved at different speeds and varied sharply by region.

Why "dark age" has force: Mughal central command contracted; Nadir Shah and Abdali exposed frontier weakness; Panipat destroyed an experienced Maratha force; Bengal faced repeated raids; revenue farming and armies pressured cultivators. Delhi, Lahore, Mathura and Surat suffered plunder.

Why it is insufficient: regional states retained capacity - Bengal maintained a revenue-commercial coalition; Saadat Khan and Safdar Jang consolidated Awadh; Asaf Jah made Hyderabad autonomous; Haidar Ali built an arsenal and disciplined army; Martanda Varma combined military reform with pepper revenue. Jaipur's planned city, Jantar Mantar and artists' shift to Lucknow show cultural vitality.

Transition in institutions: Mughal forms survived where control did not - coin, khutba, Persian chancery, nazim-diwan offices, jagir and zamindar vocabulary continued, now under regional rulers and financiers. Maratha chauth/sardeshmukhi, Sikh misls and Mysore's revenue experiments also changed state power's content.

Regional resurgence with social limits: trade, textiles, hundi finance and oceanic commerce stayed vigorous in several zones, yet a prosperous Bengal merchant cannot stand for all India; peasants, artisans and women fared differently by war corridor, caste, tenure and patronage.

Historiography: materialist interpretations explain agrarian and jagirdari stress; regional/revisionist work by Alam and Bayly explains new provincial wealth and coalitions - each strongest at a different scale.

The graded verdict is therefore: **crisis of imperial centralisation, transition of institutions, and selective regional resurgence under unequal social conditions**.

Why this earns marks: It tests all three labels across dimensions, uses named regional examples, represents competing historiographies fairly and gives a scale-specific verdict rather than an artificial compromise.

Demand decoding: Critically discuss requires testing all three labels against named evidence and reaching a graded verdict - endorsing only one label, or listing evidence without a verdict, both under-answer this question.

Why this is a 20-mark, 250-word answer: three labels, each needing supporting and limiting evidence, plus a historiography paragraph and a graded closing verdict is the right scope for 250 words at 20 marks; a 10-mark version would have to drop the historiography paragraph.

Compression plan for the exam: One paragraph each for "dark age" evidence, its insufficiency, institutional transition, and regional resurgence with social limits; one short historiography line naming at least two schools; one closing graded verdict sentence assigning each label to the level it fits best.

How to improve this answer: Make the graded verdict more explicit by naming which level (political/institutional/economic/social/cultural) each label fits best, rather than a single combined sentence - this is the exact discipline tested by the topic's weighted synthesis.

Mains 20M-2 - Examine society and economy in eighteenth-century India with attention to regional variation. (250 words)

Model answer

Eighteenth-century society and economy combined commercial resilience with fiscal coercion and durable hierarchy; regional evidence supports neither nationwide collapse nor nationwide prosperity.

Agriculture and revenue: cultivation remained the chief revenue base - in Bengal, Awadh-Banaras and parts of the south, reclamation and monetisation supported states, yet zamindars, jagirdars, revenue farmers and officials competed over the cultivator's surplus, and war, ijara and irregular exactions could worsen insecurity even where output grew. Productivity and peasant welfare must be kept separate.

Crafts and towns: cotton and silk textiles, saltpetre, indigo, arms and shipbuilding remained significant; Dacca, Murshidabad, Patna, Banaras and Masulipatnam continued production, while new regional capitals such as Lucknow,

Poona and Hyderabad attracted artisans and officials. Urban change was redistribution, not a single decline curve.

Trade and finance: European companies imported bullion for Indian goods and expanded oceanic commerce, while Hindu, Muslim and Armenian merchants remained important; the Jagat Seth house linked Bengal's treasury, mint and remittance, and hundis moved credit across regions - though fortified European factories and privilege gave commerce an increasingly coercive political edge.

Social structure: zamindars ranged from local intermediaries to rajas; caste remained strong, though military and fiscal service enabled mobility, as the Holkar rise shows. Tarabai and Ahilyabai reveal elite female agency, while peasant women worked in fields and crafts; neither justifies a uniform gender claim.

Thus the economy was regionally resilient and socially unequal: state formation created markets and careers while often transferring its fiscal cost downward.

Why this earns marks: It integrates agriculture, crafts, finance, towns, caste and gender; names regional evidence; and repeatedly qualifies aggregate claims and source visibility.

Demand decoding: Examine ... with attention to regional variation requires every claim to be tied to a named region or group, blocking any all-India generalisation about prosperity, decline, caste or gender.

Why this is a 20-mark, 250-word answer: four sub-themes (agriculture/revenue, crafts/towns, trade/finance, social structure), each needing regionally specific named evidence, plus a closing synthesis sentence is the right density for 250 words at 20 marks.

Compression plan for the exam: One paragraph per sub-theme, each opening with the regional example before the general claim (e.g. "In Bengal, Awadh-Banaras..." rather than "Agriculture generally..."); close with one sentence stating that resilience and inequality coexisted regionally, not nationally.

How to improve this answer: Add one explicit source-limit sentence - elite women such as Tarabai and Ahilyabai are visible because elite sources survive, while ordinary peasant and artisan women's conditions must be inferred more cautiously - to show awareness of evidentiary bias, not only substantive content.

PART IV coverage conclusion

Six original Mains items are retained (2x10-mark ≤150 words, 2x15-mark ≤250 words, 2x20-mark ≤250 words), selected to maximise topical breadth across state classification, Panipat, successor-state comparison, Sikh transformation and the dark-age/society-economy debates. This selection deliberately avoids duplicating content already covered by the retained PYQs, the 25 sessions or the consolidated register notes; no further Mains items are required to meet the six-item requirement.